

## MODULE 29 / 40

# Hermit Thrush

*Catharus guttatus***QUICK STATS**

|          |                                 |
|----------|---------------------------------|
| Length   | 5.5 – 7.1 in (14 – 18 cm)       |
| Wingspan | 9.8 – 11.4 in (25 – 29 cm)      |
| Weight   | 0.8 – 1.3 oz (23 – 37 g)        |
| Lifespan | Up to 11 years (avg. 4 in wild) |

**PRESENTATION**

The Hermit Thrush is widely considered to produce the most beautiful song of any North American bird — a series of ethereal, flute-like phrases of haunting purity, each beginning on a long introductory note and cascading through a series of spiraling harmonics. Walt Whitman immortalized it in "When Lilacs Last in the Dooryard Bloom'd," and it is the state bird of Vermont. Despite its modest, spotted brown plumage, the Hermit Thrush is instantly distinguished from similar thrushes by its habit of slowly raising and lowering its bright rufous tail — a unique, meditative gesture that no other North American thrush performs.

**HABITAT & RANGE**

The Hermit Thrush breeds across the boreal forests of Canada and Alaska, and in montane coniferous forests south through the Appalachians, Rockies, and Sierra Nevada. It is the only spotted thrush to winter widely in the United States — a critical identification clue in winter when other *Catharus* thrushes have departed for the tropics. In winter it frequents forest understories, dense shrubby thickets, and wooded gardens with berry-producing shrubs, from the Pacific coast to the Atlantic seaboard.

**DIET & FEEDING**

- Wild berries: holly, dogwood, mistletoe, juniper, serviceberry
- Insects and earthworms gleaned from leaf litter
- Small fruits: hackberry, pokeweed, wild grape
- Spiders and small invertebrates from the forest floor
- Mealworms offered in a low platform or ground dish
- Rarely visits seed feeders — prefers natural food in dense cover

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

The Hermit Thrush earns its name from its solitary, retiring nature — it is almost always seen alone, quietly foraging through leaf litter or perching in dense understory vegetation. Its tail-raising behavior is one of the most distinctive field marks of any North American bird: the bird slowly lifts its rufous tail to a near-vertical position, holds it briefly, then lowers it gradually — a behavior repeated constantly while the bird is perched. On the breeding grounds males are territorial, singing from high perches at dawn and dusk. In winter it is among the most solitary of thrushes, defending individual berry-producing shrubs against all comers.

NESTING & BREEDING

The Hermit Thrush nests on or near the ground in dense boreal or montane forest. The female builds a bulky cup nest of leaves, grass, and bark, well concealed beneath a low conifer or shrub. Clutches of 3–4 pale blue eggs are incubated by the female for 11–13 days. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledge at 10–15 days. Pairs raise 1–2 broods per season. The species is generally a poor cowbird host due to the remoteness of its nesting habitat.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Hermit Thrush's song stands alone in North American ornithology for its otherworldly beauty — a long, clear introductory whistle followed by a spiraling cascade of pure, harmonically rich phrases, each at a different pitch. No two phrases are alike. The song carries through dense forest with extraordinary clarity. The call is a soft, rising "veer" or a sharp "chuck" alarm note. Song is heard primarily at dawn and dusk on the breeding grounds.

CONSERVATION STATUS

|                |               |                   |        |
|----------------|---------------|-------------------|--------|
| IUCN Red List: | Least Concern | Population trend: | Stable |
|----------------|---------------|-------------------|--------|

The Hermit Thrush population is estimated at 22 million individuals and is broadly stable. As the only *Catharus* thrush to winter in North America, it is less threatened by tropical deforestation than its relatives. Climate change poses a long-term threat by shifting boreal forest composition. Window collisions during migration are a significant mortality factor, as this species migrates at night.

FEEDER TIPS

- Plant native holly, dogwood, and serviceberry — essential winter food
- Offer mealworms in a low, sheltered dish near dense shrubs
- A ground-level birdbath near dense cover is highly attractive
- Hermit Thrushes are secretive — watch for them creeping along the ground in thickets
- The key field mark: watch for the slow, deliberate tail-raising behavior

COLORING GUIDE

| ZONE        | RECOMMENDED COLOR              |
|-------------|--------------------------------|
| Back & head | Warm olive-brown               |
| Rump & tail | Bright rufous — key field mark |
| Breast      | White with bold dark spots     |
| Flanks      | Buff-gray wash                 |
| Eye ring    | Pale white — distinct          |
| Bill        | Slender, slightly curved, dark |

## COLOR ME!

Hermit Thrush • *Catharus guttatus* • Module 29

